Indus Script – A Case Study

Cracking The Indus Script

Harappans knew the art of writing. The script is found on seals, in moulded terracotta and on pottery. It has not been deciphered till now. Because the Indus texts are very short, the average length of the inscription is less than five signs. It has no bilingual text (like a Rosetta stone written in Egyptian and Greek). Hence deciphering the script is difficult. It was written generally from right to left.

- Based on computer analysis, the Russian scholar Yuri Knorozov suggested that the Indus inscriptions have a Dravidian-like word order.
- Scholar and researcher Iravatham Mahadevan, who has done extensive research on Indus civilisation, says, "We may hopefully find that the proto Dravidian roots of Harappa language and South Indian Dravidian languages are similar."
- According to Mahadevan, a stone Celt discovered in Mayiladuthurai (Tamil Nadu) has same marking as that of the symbol of the Indus script.
- In May 2007, the TamilNadu Archaeology Department found pots with arrow head symbols at Melaperumpallam near Poompuhar, which resembled the seals in Mohenjo-Daro.

According to Parpola, the sign of the Indus script is likely to represent Dravidian mono-syllabic roots.





Sign	Identification	Reading	Meaning	Sign	Identification	Reading	Meaning
a. 	halving + fish	*pacu mi*$^{-}$*n*	green star (Mercury)	a. 	fish	*mi*$^{-}$*n*	1. fish 2. star
b. 	roof + fish	*mey/may mi*$^{-}$*n*	black star (Saturn)	b. 	3 + fish	*mu(m) mi*$^{-}$*n*	three stars (Mrigasiras)
c. 	intermediate space + fish	*vel(li) mi*$^{-}$*n*	white star (Venus)	c. 	6 + fish	*caru mi*$^{-}$*n*	six stars (Pleiades)
d. 	dot/drop + fish	*pottu mi*$^{-}$*n*	1. red fish (carp) 2. red star (Rohini)	d. 	7 + fish	*elu mi*$^{-}$*n*	seven stars (Ursa Major)

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